LIGHT ON THEIR TRACKS

THE HIGH-ALTITUDE STAND-OFF WITH CHINA HAS FORCED THE INDIAN ARMY TO RECOGNISE THE NEED FOR LIGHT TANKS. A NEW PROJECT TO DESIGN AND BUILD ARMOURED VEHICLES FOR THE HIMALAYAN FRONTIER IS WAITING FOR THE GO-AHEAD

By Pradip R. Sagar



After the last round of the corps commander-level meeting recently, the Indian Army and the People's Liberation Army (PLA) of China have agreed to pull back (or disengage) from the Gogra-Hot Springs area, one of the flashpoints in eastern Ladakh. But real peace on the icy heights of the Himalayas will remain elusive until both sides agree to de-inducting forces amassed close to the border to the pre-April 2020 position. The 28-month-long military standoff has posed multiple challenges for both sides. For Indian forces, the experience has been a wake-up call on the need for some critical weaponry. At the top of the list are light tanks, something entirely missing from India's inventory, since Indian armour is meant to operate on the plains. The Chinese, for their part, have deployed light tanks designed for high-altitude operations on their side of the Line of Actual Control (LAC). The PLA's Type 15 'Black Panther' light tank, also known as ZTQ-15, is a Chinese third-generation light tank that made its appearance in Ladakh.

Now, in an effort named Project Zorawar, the Indian Army will remedy this glaring absence, pushing for the development of indigenous light tanks for faster deployment and easy manoeuvrability in high-altitude areas, and pressing the Union ministry of defence for faster approval. India, in fact, has one of the largest stables of armoured hardware in the world, with 4,300 tanks and 8,700 armoured vehicles. However, the army admits that its heavier tanks, like the Russian-origin T-72, weighing 45 tonnes, and the T-90, which weighs around 46 tonnes—both of which have been pressed into service in Ladakh—are not meant for high-altitude deployment. India's main battle tank Arjun is heavier still and can't be deployed on the China border because the 68-tonne monster is designed to counter the threat from Pakistan on the deserts or plains.

In the past, the Indian army has made effective use of light tanks in Ladakh—Stuart Mark 6 light tanks were decisive in the battle of Zojila in 1948 and the French-built AMX light tanks played a dramatic role in restricting China's advance in the western sector in 1962. In later years, however, the focus shifted entirely to heavy tanks as tensions on the Himalayan frontier with China receded for several decades.

Major General Birender Dhanoa (retired), an armoured corps officer, says that with increasing clashes with